

New Hire FAQ

50 Questions Every New Employee Asks

Onboarding • Benefits • Tools • Team • Policies • Growth

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Onboarding & First Days

Q1. What should I do on my first day?

Check in with your manager to confirm your day-one schedule. Expect to set up your laptop, complete mandatory compliance training, get an office (or virtual) tour, and meet your immediate team. Your onboarding buddy will reach out to schedule a welcome conversation.

Q2. How long is the formal onboarding period?

The structured onboarding period is 30 days, with check-ins at day 15 and day 30. Your manager will co-create 30-60-90 day goals with you during your first week so you have a clear ramp-up plan.

Q3. Who is my onboarding buddy and what do they do?

Your onboarding buddy is a peer assigned to help you navigate the culture, processes, and unwritten norms of the company. They are your go-to for informal questions. Their name is included in your welcome email.

Q4. What training is required in my first 30 days?

Required training typically includes security awareness, code of conduct, anti-harassment, and any role-specific compliance modules. All are assigned automatically in the learning management system (LMS) on day one.

Q5. Is there a new hire orientation session?

Yes. A group orientation is held regularly and covers company history, values, organizational structure, and Q&A with leadership. Your HR contact will register you for the next available session.

Q6. How do I find the company org chart?

The org chart is available in the HR portal or the internal intranet. Your onboarding buddy or manager can show you how to navigate it and help you identify key stakeholders to meet early.

Q7. What should I read before my first week ends?

Prioritize your team's charter or mission document, the employee handbook, the onboarding checklist, and any product or service overviews relevant to your role. Ask your manager for a curated reading list in your first 1:1.

Your First 90 Days

Q8. What does success look like at the end of my first 90 days?

Ask your manager to define three to five concrete outcomes during your first 1:1. Common markers include completing onboarding training, building key relationships, understanding team priorities, and delivering one tangible contribution.

Q9. Should I contribute immediately or observe at first?

The first two weeks are primarily for listening, learning, and relationship-building. Expect to ramp into active contribution by week three or four. Resist proposing changes before you understand the context.

Q10. Is it okay to ask a lot of questions as a new hire?

Yes. Asking questions is expected and encouraged in the first 90 days. A good rule: try to find the answer yourself first, then ask if you are still stuck. Thoughtful questions signal engagement, not unpreparedness.

Q11. How do I know if I am ramping up at the right pace?

Check in with your manager at the 30- and 60-day marks and ask directly whether you are meeting expectations for this stage. Do not wait for a formal review to surface misalignment.

Q12. What mistakes do new hires most commonly make?

The most common pitfalls are trying to change things before understanding them, staying heads-down instead of building relationships, missing deadlines due to unclear scope, and not asking for help when stuck.

Q13. Should I schedule 1:1s with people outside my team?

Yes. Cross-functional relationship building is one of the highest-value activities in your first 30 days. Ask your manager for a short list of five to ten people you should meet, and keep meetings to 20-30 minutes.

Q14. What if the role looks different from what was described?

Surface this early, ideally in your 30-day check-in. Frame it as curiosity rather than complaint, for example: "I want to make sure I understand how my role fits into the team's goals — can we revisit the scope?" Most misalignments are fixable when caught early.

HR, Benefits & Payroll

Q15. When do I receive my benefits enrollment link?

Benefits enrollment is sent to your email on your first day. You have 30 days from your start date to make elections. After that window, changes are only possible during open enrollment or after a qualifying life event.

Q16. What health insurance options are available?

The company typically offers multiple medical plan tiers plus dental and vision coverage. Each option has different premiums and deductibles. Review the benefits overview in the HR portal and attend a benefits Q&A session if offered.

Q17. Does the company offer a 401(k) or retirement plan?

Yes. Employees are eligible to contribute from day one. The company matches a defined percentage of your contribution — check the benefits summary for the exact match formula and vesting schedule.

Q18. How much PTO do I start with, and when can I use it?

Full-time employees accrue PTO from day one, with accrual rates varying by level. There is generally no waiting period, but confirm with your manager before scheduling time off in your first 30 days.

Q19. What parental and sick leave does the company offer?

Sick leave is typically separate from PTO. Parental leave commonly includes 12-16 weeks for primary caregivers and 2-4 weeks for secondary caregivers. Check the HR portal for the full policy applicable to your location.

Q20. When will I receive my first paycheck?

Payroll runs on a fixed cycle (bi-weekly or semi-monthly). Your first check date depends on where your start date falls in the cycle — a payroll calendar is included in your onboarding materials.

Q21. How do I set up direct deposit?

Log into the payroll portal on day one and navigate to Payroll > Direct Deposit. Enter your bank routing and account numbers. Changes take one full pay cycle, so your first payment may arrive as a paper check.

Q22. Who do I contact for payroll errors or questions?

Submit a ticket in the HR portal under Payroll Support or email the payroll team. Allow one to two business days for a response, longer near pay period close dates.

Tools, Access & IT

Q23. How do I set up my laptop on day one?

IT sends a setup guide before your start date. Follow the steps to enroll your device in device management, connect to corporate Wi-Fi or VPN, and install required applications. The IT helpdesk is available if you get stuck.

Q24. Which communication tools does the company use?

Slack (or Teams) is the primary internal messaging platform. Email is used for formal or external correspondence, and video meetings run on Zoom or Teams. Your IT setup guide covers configuration for each.

Q25. How do I request access to a system I need?

Submit an access request through the IT helpdesk portal, including the system name, business justification, and your manager's name for approval. Standard requests are typically fulfilled within one business day.

Q26. How do I connect to the VPN?

Download the VPN client listed in your IT setup guide and authenticate with your corporate single sign-on credentials. VPN is required when accessing internal systems from outside the corporate network.

Q27. Where is company documentation stored?

Documentation typically lives in Confluence, SharePoint, or a similar wiki, depending on the team. Start with the onboarding wiki linked in your welcome email, and ask your manager for the links most relevant to your role.

Q28. What do I do if my laptop breaks or is lost?

Report the issue immediately to the IT helpdesk. For a lost or stolen device, also notify your manager and IT security so the device can be remotely wiped. A loaner or replacement will be arranged.

Q29. How do I get expenses reimbursed?

Business expenses require manager pre-approval and must be submitted through the expense tool within 30 days, with receipts attached for anything over the stated threshold. The full policy is in the HR portal.

Working With Your Manager & Team

Q30. How often will I meet with my manager one-on-one?

Most managers hold weekly or bi-weekly 1:1s with direct reports. If one is not set up by the end of your first week, ask your manager to establish a recurring slot. This is your primary space for feedback and priorities.

Q31. How do I learn my manager's communication preferences?

Ask directly in your first 1:1: "How do you prefer updates — chat, email, or in our 1:1s? Do you want detail or high-level summaries?" Understanding this early prevents friction and shows self-awareness.

Q32. What should I own versus escalate to my manager?

Clarify this explicitly in your first few weeks. A useful question: "What decisions do you want me to make independently, and when should I loop you in?" Most managers prefer to be informed of surprises, not routine decisions.

Q33. How do I ask for help without seeming incompetent?

Frame requests around what you have already tried: "I've looked at X and Y but I'm stuck on Z — do you have five minutes to help me think it through?" This shows initiative and makes it easy for others to help efficiently.

Q34. What if I disagree with my manager's direction?

Share your perspective once, clearly and with supporting reasoning. If the decision stands, commit to executing it. If a recurring issue has serious consequences, escalate through your skip-level manager or HR.

Q35. How do I understand my team's current priorities?

Review any team OKRs, roadmaps, or sprint boards your manager shares. In your first team meeting, ask what the single most important thing the team is focused on right now is — then map how your role contributes to it.

Q36. What is the fastest way to earn trust with teammates?

Do what you say you will do, meet deadlines, and acknowledge when you do not know something. Reliability is the fastest path to trust, and offering to help a teammate with something small in week one goes a long way.

Q37. Does my role have on-call or after-hours expectations?

On-call rotations and escalation policies vary by team. Ask your manager whether your role carries any on-call expectations, what the escalation path looks like, and how incidents are tracked and reviewed.

Policies & Compliance

Q38. Where can I find the employee handbook?

The handbook is available in the HR portal under Policy Documents, and a link is included in your welcome email. Sign the acknowledgment that you have read it within your first week.

Q39. What is the remote or hybrid work policy?

Work arrangements vary by team and role, and your offer letter specifies yours. Discuss the practical norms — core hours, in-office days, and camera expectations — with your manager during your first 1:1.

Q40. What is the policy on using AI tools at work?

Most companies maintain an acceptable use policy for AI tools. Typical rules: do not input confidential or proprietary data, review AI-generated content before use, and use only approved platforms. Check the IT and security section of the handbook.

Q41. Can I work on a side project or freelance while employed here?

This depends on your employment agreement. Most contracts prohibit work that competes with the company or uses company IP, time, or resources. Disclose any existing side work to HR and obtain written approval.

Q42. Who owns the intellectual property I create at work?

Work created in the scope of your employment — using company time, resources, or related to company business — is generally owned by the company. Review the IP assignment clause in your employment agreement; unrelated personal projects are typically excluded.

Q43. How do I report a workplace concern or ethics violation?

Concerns can be raised with your HR business partner, your skip-level manager, or anonymously through the ethics hotline listed in the handbook. Retaliation against good-faith reporting is prohibited.

Q44. What is the social media policy?

Do not share confidential, financial, or unreleased product information publicly. Personal opinions should be clearly framed as your own and not attributed to the company. The full policy is in the handbook.

Growth, Wellbeing & Culture

Q45. How does the performance review process work?

Reviews are typically held twice a year and include self-assessment, manager evaluation, and sometimes peer feedback. Your manager will explain the framework and timeline in your first 1:1.

Q46. When am I eligible for a promotion or internal transfer?

Promotion eligibility is generally after 12-18 months in role, discussed during year-end reviews. Internal transfers follow a similar timeline, with openings posted internally first. Talk with your manager early about the path to the next level.

Q47. What mental health resources are available?

Most companies offer an Employee Assistance Program (EAP) with free, confidential counseling, referrals, and financial or legal consultations, available around the clock. The contact details are in the benefits portal.

Q48. What should I do if I feel overwhelmed in my first weeks?

This is extremely common. Talk to your manager early — most would rather adjust your ramp-up than have you quietly struggle. The EAP is also available for confidential support. Do not wait for burnout to set in.

Q49. How do I get to know colleagues and find community?

Attend team syncs, join social channels, and set up short 1:1s with key teammates in your first two weeks. Employee resource groups and interest clubs are listed on the intranet — joining one is a fast way to build connections beyond your team.

Q50. What is the cadence of all-hands or town hall meetings?

Most companies hold company-wide all-hands monthly or quarterly, with team-level syncs weekly or bi-weekly. Check the company calendar shared during onboarding for the next scheduled session.